OPTIONAL RULES · D&D 2024

Playing a Dishonored-Style Game

A Dishonored-style game is about planning: a small party studies a guarded space, picks a route, and takes it apart one quiet guard at a time, until something goes wrong.

V0.1 PLAYTEST GM GUIDANCE INSPIRED BY DISHONORED

The Map

- **Show the players a map.** They need to see the mission area to track guard movements and lines of sight and plan their routes.
- **Not everything is marked.** Secret rooms, hidden passages, air ducts, and rooftop routes can stay off the map until the players find them through exploration, scouting, Void Sight, or Foresight.
- **Enemies appear only when spotted.** A guard goes on the map once a character sees them. From then on, track their movement and patrol route as the players observe it.

- **Facing matters.** Mark which way each spotted guard is facing, with an arrow on their token or a small notch. A guard sees only in front of them, roughly the half of the map their arrow points toward, so a character who approaches from behind can stay hidden right up to the takedown. Turn a guard's facing when their patrol turns, when they hear a noise, or at the end of each mission turn if they're standing watch.

Mission Turns

Outside combat, time passes in **mission turns**, like the dungeon turns of older editions. Each turn lasts 1 minute or 5 minutes:

- **1-minute turns** for tense stretches: guards are nearby, or the party is mid-infiltration.
- **5-minute turns** for quiet stretches: moving through empty areas, waiting out a patrol, or searching an office.

During a turn, each character does one significant thing, such as crossing an area, picking a lock, scouting a room, hiding a body, or waiting in place.

At the end of each turn, the world moves:

- **Patrols advance.** Each patrolling guard ends the turn at the other end of their patrol route.
- **NPCs move.** Servants, civilians, and targets follow their own schedules.
- **The mission advances.** Events already in motion move forward, such as a shift change, a party winding down, a target heading for the vault, or a ritual nearing completion. These should change the shape of the mission in a meaningful way.

Write a timeline. Before play, jot down a short list of what happens and when, such as "Turn 4: shift change at the gate" and "Turn 10: the target leaves for the docks." Waiting then has a real cost.

When the party is discovered, or a takedown needs blow-by-blow resolution, switch to normal 6-second combat rounds.

Party and Encounters

- **Small party.** This style works best with 1 to 3 players.

- **Few enemies in any one place.** Mostly singles and pairs, spread across the map, rather than big groups in one room.
- **Room for quiet takedowns.** Give the players chances to isolate guards and remove them individually and quietly. Their first interaction with a guard ideally shouldn't alert everyone.

When Things Go Wrong

Getting discovered should feel frantic and out of control. Some ways to get there:

- **Start combat immediately.** The moment a guard raises the alarm, roll Initiative. No time to regroup.
- **Escalate every round.** While the alarm sounds, the nearest guard group arrives at the end of each round, until the party breaks line of sight.
- **Make hiding the answer.** Escaping and hiding again should usually beat fighting it out. Once the guards lose sight of the party for a few rounds, they search the area, then return to their patrols on alert.
- **It leaves a mark.** A raised alarm adds Chaos if you're using the Chaos Tracker, and an alerted area stays harder for the rest of the mission.

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